

WORDPRESS PLUGIN · USER GUIDE

MBR Live Radio Player

A complete, illustrated guide to installing, configuring and getting the very best from your audio player.

Version 3.12.6



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Licence	GPL v2 or later · free & open source
Requires	WordPress 5.2+ · PHP 7.2+ · tested to WordPress 7.0

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SECTION 1

Introduction

MBR Live Radio Player is a powerful yet straightforward WordPress plugin for embedding professional audio players on your website. Whether you are running a live internet radio station, streaming a church service, or publishing a series of podcast episodes and recordings, this plugin has you covered.

Every player is built and previewed live inside the WordPress admin. You choose your skin, set your colours, upload artwork, and see exactly what your visitors will see — before you publish a single page.

There are no external services, no accounts to create, no CDNs and no tracking. Everything runs inside your own WordPress installation.

Two ways to play

The plugin operates in one of two modes per station. **Live Stream** mode connects to an internet radio stream and displays live now-playing information. **File Player** mode turns the same player into a full playlist player for audio files you host yourself. You can mix both across your site — each station is configured independently.

Who is this guide for?

Site owners and editors who want to add a radio or audio player to a page, and developers who need the shortcode and configuration reference. No coding is required for everyday use.

New in this version

Version 3.11 adds **track artwork**: album art for the song currently playing, shown right in the player. It also introduces an **artwork lightbox** so listeners can tap the artwork for a closer look. See Section 12. The player now also handles advert breaks and news bulletins gracefully, reverting to your station artwork rather than leaving a finished song on screen.

SECTION 2

Key features at a glance

Playback

- Live radio streaming with real-time now-playing metadata and a status indicator
- Adaptive HLS (.m3u8) streaming, plus Shoutcast, Icecast and native audio formats
- File Player mode with a full playlist, progress bar and seek scrubbing
- Rewind and forward 15 seconds, and auto-advance to the next track
- Resume from the exact position a listener last left off

Artwork

- Station artwork via the WordPress featured image
- Track artwork from the stream, where the broadcaster provides it
- Optional track artwork lookup for the many stations that send a title but no image
- Tap or click any artwork to open it large in a responsive lightbox

Appearance

- Six professionally designed skins: Default, Classic (Vertical Card), Dark Flat, Ghost Bar, Retro Boombox and Slim Bar
- Custom two-colour gradient picker on the Default skin
- Dark mode and glassmorphism variants
- Fully responsive across desktop, tablet and mobile

Convenience

- Live, fully interactive preview inside the station editor
- Multi-station switching panel that slides up inside the player
- Pop-out player in a compact floating window
- Full-width sticky player docked to the top or bottom of the page

Built right

- No telemetry, no tracking, no API keys and no premium tier
- No CDN dependencies — HLS.js is bundled locally
- Player CSS and JavaScript load only on pages that contain a shortcode
- Self-hosted, cache-proof automatic updates delivered from GitHub

SECTION 3

Requirements & installation

System requirements

Requirement	Minimum	Notes
WordPress	5.2 or later	Tested up to WordPress 7.0
PHP	7.2 or later	PHP 8.x fully supported
Browser	Modern evergreen	Chrome, Firefox, Safari, Edge

Installing from a ZIP file

1. In the WordPress admin, go to **Plugins › Add New › Upload Plugin**.
2. Click **Choose File** and select the plugin ZIP.
3. Click **Install Now**, then **Activate Plugin**.
4. A new **Radio Stations** menu item will appear in the admin sidebar.

After activation

Activation registers a custom post type called **Radio Stations**. Each station you create is a single post with its own settings and its own shortcode. You are ready to build your first station.

Automatic updates

Once activated, the plugin checks for new versions automatically and delivers them straight to your WordPress Plugins screen — no marketplace account required. Updates are served from a GitHub-hosted manifest, so they are reliable and unaffected by aggressive host caching.

SECTION 4

Quick start

Your first station in five minutes.

1. Go to **Radio Stations › Add New**.
2. Enter a station name — this is used as the player title.
3. Choose a **Player Mode**: Live Stream or File Player.
4. For Live Stream, paste your stream URL. For File Player, click **Choose** to add tracks from the Media Library.
5. Optionally set a **Featured Image** to use as station artwork.
6. Pick a skin and adjust colours in the **Player Appearance** panel — watch the live preview update as you go.
7. Click **Publish**.
8. Copy the shortcode from the **Shortcode** panel and paste it into any page, post or widget.

The everyday shortcode

Placing a player is as simple as dropping its shortcode into your content. Each station has a unique numeric ID, shown in the Shortcode panel on its edit screen:

```
[mbr_radio_player id="123"]
```

Replace **123** with your own station ID. That is all that is needed for a fully working player.

SECTION 5

Creating a station

Every player begins life as a Radio Station post. The edit screen collects everything the player needs, grouped into clearly labelled panels.

Station Details

- **Title** — shown as the player heading and used as the accessible label.
- **Player Mode** — a toggle between Live Stream and File Player. The rest of the panel changes to match your choice.
- **Stream URL** (Live Stream mode) — the address of your internet radio stream.
- **Tracks** (File Player mode) — one or more audio files chosen from the Media Library.

Featured Image (artwork)

Set a WordPress Featured Image to give the player station artwork. It appears beside the controls and, in multi-station setups, updates as the listener switches stations. Artwork is optional — the player looks clean without it.

Because the artwork can now be opened full size in the lightbox, upload the largest sensible version of your logo. The player uses a scaled copy for the small panel and the original for the enlarged view.

Player Appearance

Choose a skin, toggle dark mode or glassmorphism, and — on the Default skin — pick your two gradient colours. See Section 8 for the full appearance reference.

Station Group (optional)

Select other stations here to build a switcher. A station-switching panel then appears inside the player automatically. See Section 11.

Shortcode

Once published, this panel shows the ready-to-copy shortcode for the station, including its unique ID.

SECTION 6

Live Stream mode

Live Stream mode connects the player to an internet radio stream. Once configured, it displays live now-playing metadata, a real-time status indicator, and — where several stations are grouped — seamless station switching.

Setting it up

1. Set **Player Mode** to Live Stream.
2. Paste your stream address into the **Stream URL** field.
3. Publish and place the shortcode.

What listeners see

- A play / pause control and volume slider, starting at a comfortable 25%
- A live status indicator showing whether the stream is connected
- A now-playing metadata marquee, where the stream provides it (ICY / Icecast metadata)
- Track artwork for the current song, where available (see Section 12)
- A pop-out button to open the stream in a floating window

Supported stream types

HLS (.m3u8) adaptive streams, Shoutcast (.m3u playlists, with automatic stream-URL detection), Icecast (with full ICY metadata), and direct MP3, AAC and OGG streams. Services such as BBC Radio (HLS) and SomaFM (MP3/AAC) work out of the box.

A note on metadata

Now-playing text is supplied by the stream itself. If a station does not broadcast ICY/Icecast metadata, the marquee simply stays quiet — the audio still plays perfectly. This is a property of the stream, not the player. HLS streams, including BBC Radio, generally carry no track metadata at all.

SECTION 7

File Player mode

File Player mode turns the player into a full-featured audio file player. Upload one or more files from the Media Library and the player gains a progress bar, seek scrubbing, skip controls, an auto-advancing playlist and resume-from-position.

Adding tracks

1. Set **Player Mode** to File Player.
2. Click **Choose** to open the Media Library (filtered to audio files).
3. Select one or more files. They appear as a numbered playlist.
4. Drag tracks to reorder them. The order is saved with the station.

Playback controls

- Progress bar with click-to-seek and touch scrubbing
- Rewind 15s and Forward 15s buttons
- Auto-advance to the next track when one finishes
- A slide-up track list panel for jumping between files

Resume from last position

While a file plays, the listener's position is saved to their browser's localStorage every five seconds. When they return and press play, the player seeks straight back to where they were — even after closing the browser. The saved position is cleared automatically once a track plays to the end, so the next listen starts fresh.

Recommended file format

Any format the visitor's browser supports natively will work: MP3, AAC/M4A, OGG/Vorbis, FLAC, WAV and WebM audio. MP3 has the widest cross-browser support and is recommended for public-facing playlists.

SECTION 8

Player appearance & skins

The six skins

Skin	Character
Default	Modern gradient player with a fully customisable two-colour picker
Classic (Vertical Card)	Clean, traditional styling with large uncropped square artwork
Dark Flat	Rich dark treatment for low-light and night themes
Ghost Bar	Pared-back, understated controls that recede into the page
Retro Boombox	Characterful, nostalgic styling with personality
Slim Bar	Compact single-row bar, ideal for tight spaces and headers

Colours & effects

- **Custom gradient** — on the Default skin, choose any two colours and the player blends between them.
- **Dark mode** — a darker treatment that suits dark page designs.
- **Glassmorphism** — a frosted, translucent finish that lets the background show through.
- **Artwork** — the station's featured image is shown alongside the controls.

The player credit

Every player carries a small "Made with love by Robert" credit linking to the plugin home page, styled to sit quietly within whichever skin you choose. It takes each skin's own text colour, so it reads correctly on light, dark, gradient and glassmorphism designs alike. The Ghost Bar skin omits it, in keeping with that skin's deliberately minimal styling.

The plugin is free and carries no adverts, upsells or tracking of any kind; the credit is the only thing asked in return.

Override the skin per placement

The main shortcode accepts an optional **skin** attribute, letting you use a different skin for a particular placement without changing the station's saved setting:

```
[mbr_radio_player id="123" skin="minimal"]
```

Valid skin values are: **default**, **classic**, **gradient-dark**, **minimal**, **retro** and **slim-bar**. These correspond to Default, Classic (Vertical Card), Dark Flat, Ghost Bar, Retro Boombox and Slim Bar in the admin.

SECTION 9

The live admin preview

One of the plugin's most useful features is the live preview built into the station editor. Every change you make is reflected instantly in the preview panel, so you always know exactly what visitors will see before you publish.

The preview updates for

- Skin selection and colour changes
- Dark mode and glassmorphism toggles
- Station artwork
- Title edits
- Tracks being added, removed, reordered, or picked from the Media Library (File Player mode)
- The Player Mode toggle itself

It really plays

The preview player is fully interactive. You can press play and hear your stream or your files directly inside the admin — no need to publish and open the front end just to check the sound.

SECTION 10

Shortcode reference

The plugin registers two shortcodes. In almost all cases you only need the first.

Standard player

```
[mbr_radio_player id="123"]  
[mbr_radio_player id="123" skin="gradient-dark"]
```

Attribute	Required	Description
id	Yes	The numeric ID of the Radio Station post to display
skin	No	Overrides the station's saved skin for this placement only

Sticky player

```
[mbr_radio_player_sticky id="123"]
```

Attribute	Required	Description
id	Yes	The numeric ID of the station to dock as a full-width sticky bar

Where to place shortcodes

Standard players sit anywhere in your content — pages, posts, or widget areas. The sticky player is usually added once, site-wide, via a header or footer widget area or theme template, so it is available on every page. See Section 15.

SECTION 11

Multi-station switching

If you run several stations, you can group them so that a single player offers a station switcher. Listeners tap to move between streams without the page reloading.

Setting up a group

1. Open the station that will act as the main player.
2. In the **Station Group** panel, select the other stations to include.
3. Update or publish the station.
4. A station-switching panel now slides up inside that player automatically.

Artwork follows the station

When a listener switches station, the player updates the now-playing details and the station artwork to match the newly selected stream — all without leaving the page.

Mixing modes

Grouped stations can be a mix of Live Stream and File Player stations. Each station keeps its own configuration; the group simply provides the switcher UI.

Give every station its own artwork

Each station in a group shows its own featured image, so it is worth setting a distinct one for each. Stations sharing a generic placeholder image can make the switcher look as though the artwork is not updating when in fact it is.

SECTION 12

Track artwork & the artwork lightbox

Beyond the station logo, the player can display artwork for the individual song that is playing right now — and let listeners open any artwork full size.

Where track artwork comes from

A small number of broadcasters include an image address alongside the track title in their stream metadata. Where they do, the player displays it automatically over the station logo, with no setup required.

Most stations, however, broadcast only the title — and some use that field for a homepage link rather than an image. For those, the optional **Track Artwork Lookup** fills the gap.

Track Artwork Lookup

When enabled, your server takes the broadcast track title and looks up matching album artwork from the iTunes Search API, which is free and needs no account or key. Results are cached, so at most one lookup is made per song however many listeners you have.

The feature is **off by default** because it contacts an external service. Enable it under **Radio Stations › Proxy Settings**. See Section 13 for the setting, and Section 19 for exactly what is and is not sent.

The artwork fallback chain

Situation	What the listener sees
Stream supplies real track artwork	That artwork, over the station logo
Title only, lookup enabled and matched	Album artwork found by the lookup
Title only, lookup off or no match	The station's own featured image
No station artwork set either	The artwork panel is hidden entirely

Jingles, adverts and news bulletins will not match a song, so the artwork simply reverts to your station logo until the next track begins.

Advert breaks and news

Most stations stop broadcasting track details altogether during an advert break or news bulletin. When that happens, the player reverts to your station name and station artwork, then restores the track details as soon as music resumes. The same applies if the player cannot reach your server at all: showing a song that finished ten minutes ago would be worse than showing nothing.

Track details are checked every 20 seconds, so a break is picked up promptly. A failed or refused request is treated differently: because that tells us nothing about what is playing, two in a row are needed before the display changes, which prevents a momentary network glitch from making the player flicker.

The artwork lightbox

Clicking or tapping the artwork opens it large in a modal overlay, so listeners can admire an album cover or read the small print on a station logo. It works on the standard, multi-station and sticky players.

What is shown

- The current track artwork if one is displayed, otherwise the station artwork
- The station uses your full-size uploaded image, so the enlarged view stays sharp
- A caption beneath showing the track name, or the station name

Closing it

- The close button in the corner
- Tapping or clicking anywhere outside the image
- Pressing the **Esc** key

Designed for every device

The lightbox is fully responsive: it sizes itself to the screen, adapts to landscape phones where vertical space is tight, and locks background scrolling while open. It is keyboard accessible — tab to the artwork and press Enter or Space — and it respects the operating system's reduced-motion preference.

The pop-out player does not include the lightbox, since its window is deliberately too small to benefit from one.

SECTION 13

Proxy & artwork settings

A single settings screen, at **Radio Stations › Proxy Settings**, governs how streams and artwork are fetched.

Why the proxy exists

Most radio streams are served over plain HTTP, while your WordPress site almost certainly uses HTTPS. Browsers block insecure content on secure pages, so the plugin can route such streams through your own site to keep them playable. It is enabled by default and most sites never need to touch it.

The settings

Setting	Default	What it does
Enable Stream Proxy	On	Allows HTTP streams to play on your HTTPS site. Recommended.
Proxy Mode	HTTP only	Proxy only insecure streams, or force every stream through the proxy.
Track Artwork Lookup	Off	Look up album artwork when a stream sends a title but no image.

Rate limiting

To deter abuse, the metadata endpoint limits how often an individual visitor can request now-playing information. The allowance is generous enough for many listeners sharing a single IP address, as happens on mobile networks and office connections, so ordinary listening never comes close to it. Logged-in administrators are exempt entirely, so testing your own site cannot lock you out.

If you are working with caching

After changing settings, clear any page or object cache so visitors receive the updated behaviour. This is the single most common reason a change appears not to have taken effect.

SECTION 14

Pop-out player

Every stream player includes a pop-out button. Clicking it opens the station in a compact floating window, so listeners can keep the audio going while they browse the rest of your site — or even other sites entirely.

How it behaves

- Opens a small, dedicated player window
- Playback continues uninterrupted while the listener navigates away
- Closing the window stops that playback
- Requires no configuration — it is always available on stream players

Great for engagement

The pop-out is ideal for radio and podcast sites where you want listeners to keep the audio on while they read articles, browse the schedule, or explore your archive.

SECTION 15

Sticky player

The sticky player is a full-width bar that docks to the top or bottom of the browser window and stays put as the visitor scrolls. It keeps audio controls permanently within reach.

Adding it

Place the sticky shortcode where you want it to load — typically once, site-wide, via a widget area or theme template:

```
[mbr_radio_player_sticky id="123"]
```

Behaviour

- Full browser width, docked top or bottom
- Close button — visitors can dismiss it at any time; closing pauses playback
- Never auto-starts — playback begins only when the listener presses play, respecting browser autoplay policies
- Includes the pop-out button for separate-window playback
- Shows track artwork and supports the artwork lightbox
- Responsive — the volume slider hides on narrow screens and controls stay touch-friendly

Position tip

The bottom position is generally the least intrusive and works well for most sites. The top position suits news and radio sites where constant, prominent access is expected. It inherits your station's dark-mode, glassmorphism and colour settings.

SECTION 16

Supported formats

Live streams

Format	Notes
HLS (.m3u8)	Adaptive bitrate streaming; used by BBC Radio and many broadcasters
Shoutcast	.m3u playlists with automatic stream-URL detection
Icecast	Full ICY metadata support for now-playing information
MP3 / AAC / OGG	Direct stream URLs in any browser-native audio format

File Player audio files

Format	Support
MP3	Widest cross-browser support — recommended
AAC / M4A	Broad support across modern browsers
OGG / Vorbis	Supported where the browser allows it
FLAC / WAV / WebM	Play natively in browsers that support the codec

HLS everywhere

Safari plays HLS natively. For Chrome, Firefox and Edge, the plugin bundles HLS.js locally and loads it only when an HLS stream is present — so HLS works consistently across browsers with no external dependency.

SECTION 17

Frequently asked questions

Does it work with BBC Radio, SomaFM and similar services?

Yes. Full HLS support handles BBC Radio and any other HLS stream, and MP3/AAC streams from services such as SomaFM work natively.

Why does one station show track artwork and another does not?

Track artwork depends on what the broadcaster sends. Stations that broadcast a song title can use the optional artwork lookup; those that send no metadata at all — most HLS stations, including BBC Radio — will always show your station logo instead.

Does the artwork lookup cost anything?

No. It uses the free iTunes Search API, which needs no account, key or payment. Results are cached so lookups stay minimal.

Can I have multiple stations?

Yes — create as many as you need. Each station has its own shortcode and can be placed independently.

Can I use File Player and Live Stream on the same site?

Yes. Each station is configured independently, so some can stream live while others play hosted files, all on the same site.

Does it slow down my site?

No. Player CSS and JavaScript load only on pages that contain a player shortcode, and HLS.js is loaded only when an HLS stream is present.

Does it require any external services?

Not for playback. No CDN, no tracking and no API keys. The only optional external call is the artwork lookup, which is off by default and entirely your choice.

Can I customise the player colours?

Yes. On the Default skin you can choose any two gradient colours, and six alternative pre-designed skins are also available.

How does resume-from-position work?

While a listener plays a file, their position is saved to localStorage every five seconds and restored on their next play. It is cleared automatically when a track finishes, so the next listen starts from the beginning.

Is localStorage subject to GDPR?

localStorage is treated as persistent client-side storage under ePrivacy rules, similar to cookies. A resume-position feature like this generally falls under 'functional' storage, which is typically exempt from consent — but you should assess this against your own site and applicable regulations.

SECTION 18

Troubleshooting

The player shows 'Please provide a valid radio station ID'

The shortcode is missing its id attribute, or the ID does not match a published station. Copy the exact shortcode from the station's Shortcode panel.

Audio will not start until I press play

This is expected and intentional. Browsers block autoplay of sound, so the player always waits for a deliberate play action from the listener.

No now-playing text appears on a live stream

Now-playing metadata is supplied by the stream. If the station does not broadcast ICY/Icecast metadata, the marquee stays empty while the audio plays normally.

No track artwork appears

Check that Track Artwork Lookup is enabled under Proxy Settings, and that the station actually broadcasts a track title. Stations sending no metadata cannot have their artwork looked up.

Station artwork does not change when switching stations

This is almost always an image optimisation plugin rewriting images with srcset or picture elements, or serving a stale optimised cache. Clear the optimisation cache and re-test. The player defends against this from version 3.10.3 onwards.

'Rate limit exceeded' appears in the browser console

The metadata endpoint throttles excessive requests. Log in as an administrator, which is exempt, or simply wait — the limit resets automatically.

A file will not play in a particular browser

That browser may not support the file's codec. MP3 is the safest choice for the widest compatibility; try re-encoding the file to MP3.

Appearance changes are not showing on the front end

If your site uses page or object caching, clear it after saving so visitors receive the updated markup and styles.

An HLS stream plays in Safari but not elsewhere

HLS.js loads only when an HLS stream is detected. Confirm the stream URL ends in .m3u8 and is reachable; other browsers rely on the bundled HLS.js to play it.

SECTION 19

Privacy, data & performance

What the plugin does not do

- No telemetry or usage tracking of any kind
- No third-party CDNs — all assets are served from your own site
- No accounts, API keys or external service sign-ups
- No analytics or data sent anywhere by the plugin

Track Artwork Lookup and your data

This optional feature is the plugin's only external call, and it is **off unless you switch it on**. When enabled, your server — not your visitor's browser — sends the broadcast track title to the iTunes Search API to find matching album art.

- Only the song title as broadcast is sent — nothing else
- No visitor data leaves your site: no IP addresses, no identifiers, no listening history
- The request comes from your server, so visitors are never exposed to a third party
- Results are cached, minimising how often the lookup runs at all
- Switch the setting off and no external request is ever made

Client-side storage

In File Player mode, the resume-from-position feature stores a small playback position value in the visitor's own browser using localStorage. This never leaves the visitor's device and is cleared automatically when a track completes. See the GDPR note in Section 17.

Performance

Player CSS and JavaScript are enqueued only on pages that actually contain a player shortcode, so the rest of your site is unaffected. HLS.js — the one bundled library — is loaded only when an HLS stream is present on the page.

Security hardening in 3.12.6

Version 3.12.6 is a security release, prompted by an independent review of the stream proxy. Nothing above changes: what the plugin displays, stores and sends on your behalf is exactly as described. What changed is what it will no longer permit.

- Certificate verification is enforced on every outbound connection
- Redirects are re-checked at every step, so a stream cannot send your server somewhere unintended
- Artwork addresses broadcast by the station are validated before your server will contact them
- Stream addresses are no longer written to the server error log, where a token could have been exposed
- Proxied streams have a maximum duration, and each listener a limit on simultaneous streams

An obsolete proxy file, included in the plugin folder but never used, has also been removed. If you are running an earlier version, updating is recommended.

SECTION 20

Third-party libraries

The plugin bundles a single third-party library, used only for stream playback.

HLS.js v1.4.12

Detail	Value
Purpose	Enables HLS (.m3u8) playback in browsers without native HLS support
Developer	video-dev (open source)
Licence	Apache License 2.0
Source	github.com/video-dev/hls.js
Privacy	Client-side only. Collects, stores and transmits no user data; connects only to the stream URLs you configure. No tracking or analytics.
Loading	Bundled locally and loaded only when an HLS stream is present. Safari uses native HLS and does not load it.

External services

The optional Track Artwork Lookup queries the public iTunes Search API. No library is bundled for it, no key or account is required, and it is disabled by default. See Section 19.

SECTION 21

Updates & support

Automatic updates

The plugin checks for new releases on its own and surfaces them on your WordPress Plugins screen, exactly like any other update. Version 3.12.6 delivers these updates via Plugin Update Checker 5.7 with the manifest served from GitHub, giving reliable, cache-proof update detection without a marketplace account.

Where to find help

- Plugin home and documentation: littlewebshack.com/radio
- Author: Robert Palmer — Made by Robert (madebyrobert.co.uk)

Enjoying the plugin?

MBR Live Radio Player is free and GPL-licensed, built and maintained by a single developer. If it has saved you time, a coffee is always appreciated — look for the 'Buy me a coffee' link on the plugin row on your Plugins screen. Thank you for using it.

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